

Iphigenia in Aulis

ΕΥΡΙΠΙΔΟΥ ΙΦΙΓΕΝΕΙΑ ΕΝ ΑΥΛΙΔΙ

Euripides

translated by E. P. Coleridge (1891), modernised by Perseus

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Iphigenia in Aulis

49

Scene. — The sea-coast at Aulis.

AGAMEMNON: Leda, the daughter of Thestius, had three children, maidens, Phoebe, Clytemnestra my wife, and Helen; the foremost of the favored sons of Hellas came to woo Helen; but terrible threats of spilling his rival's blood were uttered by each of them, if he should fail to win the girl. Now the matter filled Tyndareus, her father, with perplexity, whether to give her or not, how he might best succeed. This thought occurred to him: the suitors should swear to each other and join right hands and pour libations with burnt-sacrifice, binding themselves by this curse: whoever wins the child of Tyndareus for wife, they will assist that man, in case a rival takes her from his house and goes his way, robbing her husband of his rights; and march against that man in armed array and raze his city to the ground, Hellene no less than barbarian. Now when they had once pledged their word and old Tyndareus with no small cleverness had beguiled them by his shrewd device, he allowed his daughter to choose from among her suitors the one towards whom¹ the sweet breezes of Aphrodite might carry her. Her choice fell on Menelaus; would she had never taken him! Then there came to Lacedaemon from the Phrygians the man who, Argive legend says, judged the goddesses' dispute; in robes of gorgeous hue, ablaze with gold, in true barbaric pomp; and he, finding Menelaus gone from home, carried Helen off, in mutual desire, to his steading on Ida. Goaded to frenzy, Menelaus flew through Hellas, invoking the ancient oath exacted by Tyndareus and declaring the duty of helping the injured husband.

80

AGAMEMNON: And so the Hellenes, brandishing their spears and donning their harness, came here to the narrow straits of Aulis with armaments of ships and troops, with many horses and chariots, and

they chose me to captain them all² for the sake of Menelaus, since I was his brother. Would that some other had gained that distinction instead of me! But after the army was gathered and come together, we still remained at Aulis weatherbound. In our perplexity, we asked Calchas, the seer, and he answered that we should sacrifice my own child Iphigenia to Artemis, whose home is in this land, and we would sail and sack the Phrygians' capital [if we sacrificed her, but if we did not, these things would not happen].³ When I heard this, I commanded Talthybius with loud proclamation to disband the whole army, as I could never bear to slay my daughter. Whereupon my brother, bringing every argument to bear, persuaded me at last to face the crime; so I wrote in a folded scroll and sent to my wife, bidding her despatch our daughter to me on the pretence of wedding Achilles, at the same time magnifying his exalted rank and saying that he refused to sail with the Achaeans, unless a bride of our lineage should go to Phthia. Yes, this was the inducement I offered my wife, [inventing, as I did, a sham marriage for the maiden. Of all the Achaeans we alone know the real truth, Calchas, Odysseus, Menelaus and myself; but that which I then decided wrongly, I now rightly countermand again in this scroll, which you, old man, have found me opening and resealing beneath the shade of night. Up now and away with this missive to Argos, and I will tell you by word of mouth all that is written here, the contents of the folded scroll, for you are loyal to my wife and house.]

1

AGAMEMNON: Old man, come here and stand before my dwelling.

2

OLD MAN: I come; what new schemes now, king Agamemnon?

3

AGAMEMNON: Will you hurry?

OLD MAN: I am hurrying. It is little enough sleep old age allows me and keenly it watches over my eyes.

6

AGAMEMNON: What can that star be, steering its course there?

7

OLD MAN: Sirius, still shooting over the zenith on his way near the Pleiads' sevenfold track.

9

AGAMEMNON: ⁴ The birds are still at any rate and the sea is calm, hushed are the winds, and silence broods over the Euripus.

12

OLD MAN: Then why are you outside your tent, why so restless, my lord Agamemnon? All is yet quiet here in Aulis, the watch on the walls is not yet astir. Let us go in.

16

AGAMEMNON: I envy you, old man, yes, and every man who leads a life secure, unknown and unrenowned; but little I envy those in office.

20

OLD MAN: And yet it is there that we place the be-all and end-all of existence.⁵

21

AGAMEMNON: Yes, but that is where the danger comes; and ambition,⁶ sweet though it seems, brings sorrow with its near approach. At one time the unsatisfied claims of the gods upset our life, at another the numerous peevish fancies of our subjects shatter it.

28

OLD MAN: I do not like these sentiments in one who is a chief. It was not to enjoy all blessings that Atreus begot you, Agamemnon; but you must experience joy and sorrow alike, mortal as you are. Even though you like it not, this is what the gods decree. But you, after letting your taper spread its light abroad, write the letter which is still in your hands and then erase the same words again, sealing and reopening the tablet, then flinging it to the ground with floods of tears, and leaving nothing undone in your aimless behavior to stamp you mad. What is it that troubles you? what news is there affecting you,⁷ king? Come,

share with me your story; you will be telling it to a loyal and trusty heart; for Tyndareus sent me that day to form part of your wife's dowry and to wait upon the bride with loyalty.

115

AGAMEMNON: "Daughter of Leda, in addition to my first letter, I am sending you word —."

117

OLD MAN: Say on and make it plain, that what my tongue utters may accord with what you have written.

119

AGAMEMNON: "Not to despatch your daughter to Euboea's deep-gulfed wing, to the waveless bay of Aulis, for after all we will celebrate our child's wedding at another time."

124

OLD MAN: And how will Achilles, cheated of his bride, curb the fury of his indignation against you and your wife? Here also is a danger.⁸ Make clear what you are saying.

128

AGAMEMNON: It is his name, not himself that Achilles is lending, knowing nothing of the marriage or of my scheming or my professed readiness to betroth my daughter to him for a husband's embrace.⁹

133

OLD MAN: A dreadful venture yours, king Agamemnon, you that, by promise of your daughter's hand to the son of the goddess, were bringing the maid here to be sacrificed for the Danaids.

136

AGAMEMNON: Ah me! I am utterly distraught; alas! bewilderment comes over me. Away! hurry your steps, yielding nothing to old age.

140

OLD MAN: I will make haste, king.

141

AGAMEMNON: Do not sit down by woodland fountains; scorn the witcheries of sleep.

143

OLD MAN: Hush!¹⁰

144

AGAMEMNON: And when you pass any place where roads diverge, cast your eyes all round, taking heed that no mule-wagon escape you, passing by on rolling wheels, bearing my child to the ships of the Danaids.

149

OLD MAN: It shall be so.

AGAMEMNON: Start then from the bolted gates,¹¹ and if you meet the escort, start them back again, and drive at full speed to the abodes of the Cyclopes.

153

OLD MAN: But tell me, how shall my message find credit with your wife or child?

155

AGAMEMNON: Preserve the seal which you bear on this tablet. Away! Already the dawn is growing grey, lighting the lamp of day and the fire of the sun's four steeds; help me in my trouble. (*Exit Old man.*) No mortal is prosperous or happy to the last, for no one was ever born to a painless life.

163

Exit Agamemnon.

164

CHORUS: To the sandy beach of sea-coast Aulis I have come after a voyage through the tides of narrow Euripus, leaving Chalcis, my city which feeds the waters of far-famed Arethusa near the sea, so that I might behold the army of the Achaeans and the ships rowed by those godlike heroes; for our husbands tell us that fair-haired Menelaus and high-born Agamemnon are leading them to Troy on a thousand ships

in quest of Helen, whom Paris the herdsman carried off from the banks of reedy Eurotas, his gift from Aphrodite, when that queen of Cyprus entered beauty's contest with Hera and Pallas at the gushing fountain.¹²

185

CHORUS: Through the grove of Artemis, rich with sacrifice, I sped my course, my cheek stained with red from maiden modesty, in my eagerness to see the soldiers' camp, the tents of the mail-clad Danaids, and their crowd of horses.¹³ I saw two met together in council; one was Aias, son of Oileus; the other Aias, son of Telamon, crown of glory to the men of Salamis; and I saw Protesilaus and Palamedes, sprung from the son of Poseidon, sitting there amusing themselves with intricate figures at checkers; Diomedes too at his favorite sport of hurling quoits; and Meriones, Ares' son, a marvel to mankind, stood at his side; likewise I beheld the son of Laertes, who came from his island hills, and with him Nireus, handsomest of the Achaeans.

206

CHORUS: Achilles next, that nimble runner, swift on his feet as the wind, whom Thetis bore and Chiron trained, I saw upon the beach, racing in full armor along the shingle, and straining every nerve to beat a team of four horses, as he sped round the track on foot; and Eumelus, the grandson of Pheres, their driver, was shouting when I saw him, goading on his lovely steeds, with their bits of chased gold-work; the center pair, that bore the yoke, had dappled coats picked out with white, while the tracehorses, on the outside, facing the turning-post in the course,¹⁴ were bays with spotted fetlocks. Close beside them Peleus' son leapt on his way, in all his harness, keeping abreast the rail by the axle-box.

231

CHORUS: Next I sought the countless fleet, a wonder to behold, that I might fill my girlish eyes with gazing, a sweet¹⁵ delight. The warlike Myrmidons from Phthia held the right wing with fifty swift cruisers,

upon whose sterns, right at the ends, stood Nereid goddesses in golden effigy, the ensign of Achilles' armament.

242

CHORUS: Near these were moored the Argive ships in equal numbers, over which Mecisteus' son, whom Talaus his grandfather reared, and Sthenelus, son of Capaneus, were in command; next in order, Theseus' son was stationed at the head of sixty ships from Attica, having the goddess Pallas set in a winged chariot drawn by steeds with solid hoof, a lucky sight for mariners.

253

CHORUS: Then I saw Boeotia's fleet of fifty sails decked with ensigns; these had Cadmus at the stern holding a golden dragon at the beaks of the vessels, and earth-born Leitus was their admiral. And there were ships from Phocis; and from Locris came the son of Oileus with an equal contingent, leaving famed Thronium's citadel.

265

CHORUS: And from Mycenae, the Cyclopes' town, Atreus' son sent a hundred well-manned galleys, and his brother¹⁶ was with him in command, as friend with friend, that Hellas might exact vengeance on the one who had fled her home to wed a foreigner. Also I saw upon Gerenian Nestor's prows from Pylos the ensign of his neighbour Alpheus, four-footed like a bull.

277

CHORUS: Moreover there was a squadron of twelve Aenianian sail under King Gouneus; and then near them the lords of Elis, whom all the people named Epeians; and Eurytus was lord of these; Likewise he led the Taphian warriors with the white oar-blades, the subjects of Meges, son of Phyleus, who had left the isles of the Echinades, where sailors cannot land.

288

CHORUS: Lastly, Aias, reared in Salamis, was joining his right wing to the left¹⁷ of those near whom he was posed, closing the line with his outermost ships, twelve barques obedient to the helm, as I heard and

then saw the crews; the one who brings his barbaric boats to grapple Aias shall obtain no safe return. There I saw¹⁸ the naval armament, but some things I heard at home about the gathered army, of which I still have a recollection.

303

OLD MAN: (*as Menelaus wrests a letter from him.*) Strange daring yours, Menelaus, where you have no right.

304

MENELAUS: Stand back! You carry loyalty to your master too far.

305

OLD MAN: The very reproach you have for me is to my credit.

306

MENELAUS: You shall rue it, if you meddle in matters that do not concern you.

307

OLD MAN: You had no right to open a letter, which I was carrying.

308

MENELAUS: No, nor you to be carrying sorrow to all Hellas.

309

OLD MAN: Argue that point with others, but surrender that letter to me.

310

MENELAUS: I shall not let go.

OLD MAN: Nor will I let loose my hold.

311

MENELAUS: Why then, this staff of mine will be dabbling your head with blood before long.

312

OLD MAN: To die in my master's cause would be a noble death.

313

MENELAUS: Let go! you are too wordy for a slave.

314

OLD MAN: (*seeing Agamemnon approaching*) Master, he is wronging me; he snatched your letter violently from my grasp, Agamemnon, and will not heed the claims of right.

317

AGAMEMNON: Ah! what is this uproar at the gates, this indecent brawling?

318

MENELAUS: My tale, not his, has the better right to be spoken.

319

AGAMEMNON: You, Menelaus! what quarrel do you have with this man, why are you dragging him here?

Exit ATTENDANT.

320

MENELAUS: Look me in the face! May that be the prelude to my story.

321

AGAMEMNON: Shall I, the son of Atreus, close my eyes from fear?¹⁹

322

MENELAUS: Do you see this tablet, the bearer of a shameful message?

323

AGAMEMNON: I see it, yes; now, you first of all surrender it.

324

MENELAUS: No, not till I have shown its contents to all the army.

325

AGAMEMNON: What! have you broken the seal and know already what you should never have known?

326

MENELAUS: Yes, I opened it and know to your sorrow the secret machinations of your heart.

327

AGAMEMNON: Where did you get it? O gods! what shameless heart you have!

328

MENELAUS: I was awaiting your daughter's arrival at the camp in Argos.

329

AGAMEMNON: What right have you to watch my doings? is not this a proof of shamelessness?

330

MENELAUS: My wish to do it gave the spur, for I am no slave to you.

331

AGAMEMNON: Infamous! Am I not to be allowed the management of my own house?

332

MENELAUS: No, for you think crooked thoughts, one thing now, another formerly, and something different presently.

333

AGAMEMNON: Most exquisite refining on evil themes!²⁰ A hateful thing the tongue of cleverness!

334

MENELAUS: Yes, but a mind unstable is an unjust possession, disloyal to friends. Now I am anxious to test you, and do not seek from rage to turn aside from the truth, nor will I on my part overstrain²¹ the case. Do you remember when you were all eagerness to captain the Danaids against Troy, making a pretence of declining, though eager for it in your heart; how humble you were then, taking each man by the hand and keeping open doors for every fellow-townsmen who cared to enter, affording each in turn chance to speak with you, even though some did not wish it, seeking by these methods to purchase popularity from all bidders? Then when you had secured the command, there came a change over your manners; you were no longer so cordial as before to former friends, but hard of access, seldom to be found at home. But the man of real worth ought not to change his manners in the hour of prosperity, but should then show himself most staunch to friends, when his own good fortune can help them most effectually.

This was the first cause I had to reprove you, for it was here I first discovered your villainy; but afterwards, when you came²² to Aulis with all the gathered hosts of Hellas, you were of no account; no! the want of a favorable breeze filled you with consternation at the chance dealt out by the gods.²³ Then the Danaids began demanding that you should send the fleet away instead of vainly toiling on at Aulis; what dismay and confusion was then depicted in your looks, to think that you, with a thousand ships at your command, had not occupied the plains of Priam with your armies! And you would ask my counsel, “What am I to do? What scheme can I devise, where find one?”—to save yourself being stripped of your command and losing your fair fame. Next when Calchas bade you offer your daughter in sacrifice to Artemis, declaring that the Danaids should then sail, you were overjoyed,²⁴ and gladly undertook to offer the girl, and of your own accord—never allege compulsion—you are sending word to your wife to despatch your daughter here on pretence of wedding Achilles. And after all you turn round and have been caught casting your letter to this effect: “I will no longer be my daughter’s murderer.” Exactly so!²⁵ This is the same air that heard you say it.²⁶ Countless others have done the same; they make an effort while in power, and then retire dishonorably, sometimes owing to the senselessness of the citizens, sometimes deservedly, because they are too feeble of themselves to maintain their watch upon the state. For my part, I am more sorry for our unhappy Hellas, whose purpose was to read these worthless foreigners a lesson, while now she will let them escape and mock her, thanks to you and your daughter. May I never appoint a man to rule my country or lead its warriors because of his kinship!²⁷ Sense is what the general must have; since any man, with ordinary intelligence, can govern a state.²⁸

376

CHORUS LEADER: For brothers to come to words and blows, whenever they disagree, is terrible.

378

AGAMEMNON: I wish to rebuke you in turn,²⁹ briefly, not lifting my eyes too high shamelessly, but in more sober fashion, as a brother; for it is a good man's way to be considerate. Tell me, why this burst of fury, these bloodshot eyes? who wrongs you? what is it you want? are you longing to have a virtuous wife? Well, I cannot supply you; for she, whom you once had, was ill-controlled by you. Am I then, a man who never went astray, to suffer for your sins? or is it my popularity that galls you? No! it is the longing you have to keep a beautiful woman in your embrace, casting reason and honor to the winds. A bad man's pleasures are like himself. Am I mad, if I change to wiser counsels, after previously deciding amiss? Yours is the madness rather in wishing to recover a wicked wife, once you had lost her—a stroke of heaven-sent luck. Those foolish suitors swore that oath to Tyndareus in their longing to wed; but Hope was the goddess that led them on,³⁰ I think, and she it was that brought it about rather than you and your strength. So take the field with them; they are ready for it³¹ in the folly of their hearts; for the deity is not without insight, but is able to discern where oaths have been wrongly pledged or forcibly extorted. I will not slay my children, nor³² shall your interests be prospered by justice in your vengeance for a worthless wife, while I am left wasting, night and day, in sorrow for what I did to one of my own flesh and blood, contrary to all law and justice. Here is your answer shortly given, clear and easy to understand; and if you will not come to your senses, I shall do the best for myself.

402

CHORUS LEADER: This differs from your previous declaration, but there is good in it, your child's reprieve.

404

MENELAUS: Ah me, how sad my lot! I have no friends then after all.

405

AGAMEMNON: Friends you have, if you do not seek their destruction.

406

MENELAUS: Where will you find any proof that you are sprung from the same father as I?

407

AGAMEMNON: It is your moderation, not your madness, that I share by nature.

408

MENELAUS: Friends should sympathize with friends in sorrow.

409

AGAMEMNON: Claim my help by kindly service, not by paining me.

410

MENELAUS: So you have no mind to share this trouble with Hellas?

411

AGAMEMNON: No, Hellas is diseased like you, according to some god's design.

412

MENELAUS: Go boast of your scepter, after betraying your own brother! while³³ I will seek some different means and other friends.

414

MESENTER: (*entering hurriedly.*) Agamemnon, lord of Hellas! I have come and bring you your daughter, whom you call Iphigenia in your home; and her mother, your wife Clytemnestra, is with her, and the child Orestes, a sight to gladden³⁴ you after your long absence from your home; but they had been travelling long and far, they are now resting their tender feet at the waters of a fair spring, they and their horses, for we turned these loose in the grassy meadow to browse their fill. But I have come as their forerunner to prepare you for their reception; for the army knows already of your daughter's arrival, so quickly did the rumor spread; and all the people are running together to the sight, that they may see your child; for Fortune's favorites enjoy world-wide fame and have all eyes fixed on them. Some say: "Is it a wedding, or what is happening? or has king Agamemnon from fond yearning summoned his daughter here?" From others you would have

heard: “They are presenting the maiden to Artemis, queen of Aulis, previous to marriage; who can the bridegroom be, that is to lead her home?” Come, then, begin the rites, that is the next step, by getting the baskets ready; crown your heads—you too,³⁵ lord Menelaus; prepare the wedding hymn; let flutes sound throughout the tents with noise of dancer’s feet; for this is a happy day, that has come for the maid.

440

AGAMEMNON: You have my thanks; now go within; for the rest it will be well, as Fate proceeds. (*Exit Messenger.*) Ah, woe is me! unhappy wretch, what can I say? where shall I begin? To what cruel straits have I been plunged! A god has outwitted me, proving far cleverer than any cunning of mine. What an advantage humble birth possesses! for it is easy for her sons to weep and tell out all their sorrows; while to the high-born man come these same sorrows, but we have dignity throned over our life and are the people’s slaves.³⁶ I, for instance, am ashamed to weep, and no less ashamed, poor wretch, to check my tears at the dreadful pass to which I am brought. Enough; what am I to tell my wife? how shall I welcome her? with what face meet her? for she too has undone me by coming uninvited in this my hour of sorrow; yet it was only natural she should come with her daughter to prepare the bride and perform the fondest duties, where she will discover my villainy. And for this poor maid—why maid? Death, it seems, will soon make her his bride—how I pity her! Thus will she plead to me, I think: “My father, will you slay me? May you yourself make such a marriage, and whoever is a friend to you!” While Orestes, from his station near us, will cry in childish accents, inarticulate, yet fraught with meaning. Alas! to what utter ruin Paris, the son of Priam, the cause of these troubles, has brought me by his union with Helen!

469

CHORUS LEADER: I pity her myself, as a woman who is a stranger may grieve for the misfortunes of royalty.

471

MENELAUS: (*offering his hand.*) Your hand, brother! let me grasp it.

472

AGAMEMNON: I give it; yours is the victory, mine the sorrow.

473

MENELAUS: By Pelops our reputed grandsire and Atreus our father, I swear to tell you the truth from my heart, without any covert purpose, but only what I think. The sight of you in tears made me pity you, and in return I shed a tear for you myself; I withdraw from my former proposals, ceasing to be a cause of fear to you; yes, and I will put myself in your present position;³⁷ and I counsel you, do not slay your child or prefer my interests to yours; for it is not just that you should grieve, while I am glad, or that your children should die, while mine still see the light of day. What is it, after all, I seek? If I am set on marriage, could I not find a bride as choice elsewhere? Was I to lose a brother—the last I should have lost—to win a Helen, getting bad for good? I was mad, impetuous as a youth, till I perceived, on closer view, what slaying children really meant. Moreover I am filled with compassion for the hapless maiden, doomed to bleed that I may wed, when I reflect that we are kin. What has your daughter to do with Helen? Let the army be disbanded and leave Aulis; dry those streaming eyes, brother, and do not provoke me to tears. Whatever concern you have in oracles that affect your child, let it be none of mine; into your hands I resign my share. A sudden change, you'll say, from my dread proposals? A natural course for me; affection for my brother caused the change. These are the ways of a man not devoid of virtue, to pursue on each occasion what is best.

504

CHORUS LEADER: A generous speech, worthy of Tantalus, the son of Zeus; you do not shame your ancestry.

506

AGAMEMNON: I thank you, Menelaus, for this unexpected suggestion; it is an honorable proposal, worthy of you. Sometimes love, sometimes the selfishness of their families, causes a quarrel between brothers; I

loathe a relationship of this kind which is bitterness to both.³⁸ But it is useless, for circumstances compel me to carry out the murderous sacrifice of my daughter.

513

MENELAUS: How so? who will compel you to slay your own?

514

AGAMEMNON: The whole Achaean army here assembled.

515

MENELAUS: Not if you send her back to Argos.

516

AGAMEMNON: I might do that unnoticed, but there will be another thing I cannot.

517

MENELAUS: What is that? You must not fear the mob too much.

518

AGAMEMNON: Calchas will tell the Argive army his oracles.

519

MENELAUS: Not if he should die before that—an easy matter.

520

AGAMEMNON: The whole tribe of seers is a curse with its ambition.

521

MENELAUS: Yes, and good for nothing and useless, when among us.

522

AGAMEMNON: Has the thought, which is rising in my mind, no terrors for you?

523

MENELAUS: How can I understand your meaning, unless you declare it?

524

AGAMEMNON: The son of Sisyphus knows all.

525

MENELAUS: Odysseus cannot possibly hurt us.

526

AGAMEMNON: He was ever shifty by nature, siding with the mob.

527

MENELAUS: True, he is enslaved by the love of popularity, a fearful evil.

528

AGAMEMNON: Don't you think, then, he will arise among the Argives and tell them the oracles that Calchas delivered, saying of me that I undertook to offer Artemis a victim, and after all am proving false? Then, when he has carried the army away with him, he will bid the Argives slay us and sacrifice the girl; and if I escape to Argos, they will come and destroy the place, razing it to the ground, Cyclopean walls and all. That is my trouble. Woe is me! to what perplexities the gods have brought me at this pass! Take one precaution for me, Menelaus, as you go through the army, that Clytemnestra does not learn this, till I have taken my child and devoted her to death, that my affliction may be attended with the fewest tears. (*Turning to the Chorus.*) And you, foreign women, keep silence.

542

Exit Menelaus.

543

CHORUS: Happy are they who find the goddess come in moderate might, sharing with self-restraint in Aphrodite's gift of marriage and enjoying calm and rest from frenzied passions, where the Love-god, golden-haired, stretches his charmed bow with twin arrows, and one is aimed at happiness, the other at life's confusion. O lady Cypris, queen of beauty! far from my bridal bower I ban the last. Be mine delight in moderation and pure desires, and may I have a share in love, but shun excess!

558

CHORUS: Men's natures vary, and their habits differ, but virtue is always manifest. Likewise the training that come of education conduces greatly to virtue; for not only is modesty wisdom, but it has

also the rare grace³⁹ of seeing by its better judgment what is right; whereby a glory, ever young, is shed over life by reputation. A great thing it is to hunt virtue, for women when they love secretly; while in men, an inborn sense of order, shown in countless ways,⁴⁰ adds to a city's greatness.

573

CHORUS: You came, O Paris, to the place where you were reared to herd the cows among the white heifers of Ida, piping in foreign strain and breathing on your reeds an echo of the Phrygian airs Olympus played. Full-uddered cows were browsing at the spot where⁴¹ that verdict between goddesses was awaiting you—the cause of your going to Hellas to stand before the ivory palace, kindling love in Helen's entranced eyes and feeling its flutter in your own breast; from which the fiend of strife brought Hellas with her spear and ships to the towers of Troy.

590

CHORUS OF ARGIVE MEN: Oh! great is the bliss the great enjoy. Behold Iphigenia, the king's child, my lady, and Clytemnestra, the daughter of Tyndareus; how proud their lineage! how high their pinnacle of fortune! These mighty ones, whom wealth attends, are very gods in the eyes of less favored folk.

598

CHORUS: Let us stand here, maidens of Chalcis, and lift the queen from her chariot to the ground without stumbling, supporting her gently in our arms, with kind intent, that the renowned daughter of Agamemnon, just arrived, may feel no fear; strangers ourselves, let us avoid anything that may disturb or frighten the strangers from Argos.⁴²

607

CLYTEMNESTRA: I take this as a lucky omen, your kindness and auspicious greeting, and have good hope that it is to a happy marriage I conduct the bride. (*To attendants.*) Take from the chariot the dowry I am bringing for my daughter and convey it within with careful heed.

My daughter, leave the horse-drawn chariot, planting your faltering footstep delicately.⁴³ *(To the Chorus.)* Young women,⁴⁴ take her in your arms and lift her from the chariot, and let one of you give me the support of her hand, that I may quit my seat in the carriage with fitting grace. Some of you stand at the horses' heads; for the horse has a timid eye, easily frightened; here, take this child Orestes, son of Agamemnon, baby as he still is. What! sleeping, little one, tired out by your ride in the chariot? Awake to bless your sister's wedding; for you, my gallant boy, shall get by this marriage a kinsman gallant as yourself, the Nereid's godlike offspring. Come here to your mother, my daughter, Iphigenia, and seat yourself beside me, and stationed near show my happiness to these strangers; yes, come here and welcome the father you love so dearly.⁴⁵

631

IPHIGENIA: Do not be angry with me, mother, if I run from your side and throw myself on my father's breast.

633

CLYTEMNESTRA: Hail! my honored lord, king Agamemnon! we have obeyed your commands and have come.⁴⁶

635

IPHIGENIA: [O my father! I long to outrun others and embrace you after this long while;] for I yearn to see your face; do not be angry with me.

638

CLYTEMNESTRA: You may do so, daughter; for of all the children I have borne, you have always loved your father best.

640

IPHIGENIA: *(throwing herself into Agamemnon's arms.)* I see you, father, joyfully after a long time.

641

AGAMEMNON: And I, your father, see you; your words do equal duty for both of us.

642

IPHIGENIA: All hail, father! you did well in bringing me here to you.

643

AGAMEMNON: I know not how I am to say yes or no to that, my child.

644

IPHIGENIA: Ah! how wildly you are looking, spite of your joy at seeing me.

645

AGAMEMNON: A man has many cares when he is king and general too.

646

IPHIGENIA: Be mine, all mine today; do not turn to moody thoughts.

647

AGAMEMNON: Why so I am, all yours today; I have no other thought.

648

IPHIGENIA: Then smooth your knitted brow, unbend and smile.

649

AGAMEMNON: See! my child, my joy at seeing you is even as it is.

650

IPHIGENIA: And do you then have tears streaming from your eyes?

651

AGAMEMNON: Yes, for long is the absence from each other, that awaits us.

652

IPHIGENIA: I do not know, dear father, I do not know of what you are speaking.⁴⁷

653

AGAMEMNON: You are moving my pity all the more by speaking so sensibly.

654

IPHIGENIA: My words shall turn to senselessness if that will cheer you more.

655

AGAMEMNON: Alas! this silence is too much. You have my thanks.

656

IPHIGENIA: Stay with your children at home, father.

657

AGAMEMNON: My own wish!⁴⁸ But to my sorrow I may not

658

IPHIGENIA: Ruin seize their wars and the woes of Menelaus!

659

AGAMEMNON: First will that, which has been my life-long ruin, bring ruin to others.⁴⁹

660

IPHIGENIA: How long you were absent in the bays of Aulis!

661

AGAMEMNON: Yes, and there is still a hindrance to my sending the army forward.

662

IPHIGENIA: Where do men say the Phrygians live, father?

663

AGAMEMNON: In a land where I wish Paris, the son of Priam, never had dwelt.

664

IPHIGENIA: It is a long voyage you are bound on, father, after you leave me.

665

AGAMEMNON: You will meet your father again, my daughter.

666

IPHIGENIA: Ah! would it were seemly for you to take me as a fellow voyager!⁵⁰

667

AGAMEMNON: You too have⁵¹ a voyage to make to a haven where you will remember your father.

668

IPHIGENIA: Shall I sail there with my mother or alone?

669

AGAMEMNON: All alone, without father or mother.

670

IPHIGENIA: What! have you found me a new home, father?

671

AGAMEMNON: Enough of this! it is not for girls to know such things.

672

IPHIGENIA: Please hurry home from Troy, father, as soon as you have triumphed there.

673

AGAMEMNON: There is a sacrifice I have first to offer here.

674

IPHIGENIA: Yes, it is your duty to heed religion with aid of holy rites.⁵²

675

AGAMEMNON: You will witness it, for you will be standing near the libations.

676

IPHIGENIA: Am I to lead the dance then round the altar, father?

677

AGAMEMNON: I count you happier than myself because you know nothing. Go within—it is wrong for maidens to be seen—after you have given me your hand and a kiss, on the eve of your lengthy sojourn far from your father's side. Breast, cheek, and golden hair! ah, how grievous you have found Helen and the Phrygians' city! I can speak no more; the tears come welling to my eyes, the moment I touch you. Go into the house. (*Exit Iphigenia.*) (*Agamemnon turns to Clytemnestra.*) I beg your pardon, daughter of Leda, if I showed excessive grief at the thought of giving my daughter to Achilles; for though we are sending her to taste of bliss, still it wrings a parent's heart, when he, the father who has toiled so hard for them, commits his children to the homes of strangers.

691

CLYTEMNESTRA: I am not so senseless; But I think I will go through this as well, when I lead the girl from the chamber to the sound of the marriage hymn; so I do not chide you; but custom will combine with time to make the smart grow less. As for him, to whom you have betrothed our daughter, I know his name, it is true, but want to learn his lineage and the land of his birth.

697

AGAMEMNON: There was one Aegina, the daughter of Asopus.

698

CLYTEMNESTRA: Who wedded her? Some mortal or a god?

699

AGAMEMNON: Zeus, and she bore Aeacus, the prince of Oenone.⁵³

700

CLYTEMNESTRA: What son of Aeacus secured his father's halls?

701

AGAMEMNON: Peleus, who wedded the daughter of Nereus.

702

CLYTEMNESTRA: With the god's consent, or when he had taken her in spite of gods?

703

AGAMEMNON: Zeus betrothed her, and her guardian gave consent.

704

CLYTEMNESTRA: Where did he marry her? in the billows of the sea?

705

AGAMEMNON: In Chiron's home, at sacred Pelion's foot.

706

CLYTEMNESTRA: What! the abode ascribed to the race of Centaurs?

707

AGAMEMNON: It was there the gods celebrated the marriage feast of Peleus.

708

CLYTEMNESTRA: Did Thetis or his father train Achilles?

709

AGAMEMNON: Chiron brought him up, to prevent his learning the ways of the wicked.

710

CLYTEMNESTRA: Ah! wise the teacher, still wiser the one who gave his son.

711

AGAMEMNON: Such is the future husband of your daughter.

712

CLYTEMNESTRA: A blameless lord; but what city in Hellas is his?

713

AGAMEMNON: He dwells on the banks of the river Apidanus, in the borders of Phthia.

714

CLYTEMNESTRA: Will you convey⁵⁴ our daughter there?

715

AGAMEMNON: He who takes her to himself will see to that.

716

CLYTEMNESTRA: Happiness attend the pair! Which day will he marry her?

717

AGAMEMNON: As soon as the full moon comes to give its blessing

718

CLYTEMNESTRA: Have you already offered the goddess a sacrifice to usher in the maiden's marriage?

719

AGAMEMNON: I am about to do so; that is the very thing I was engaged in.

720

CLYTEMNESTRA: And then will you celebrate the marriage feast afterwards?

721

AGAMEMNON: Yes, when I have offered a sacrifice required by the gods of me.

722

CLYTEMNESTRA: But where am I to make ready the feast for the women?

723

AGAMEMNON: Here beside our gallant Argive ships.

724

CLYTEMNESTRA: Finely here! but still I must;⁵⁵ good come of it for all that!

725

AGAMEMNON: Do you know what to do, lady? Then obey me.

726

CLYTEMNESTRA: In what matter? for I was ever accustomed to obey you.

727

AGAMEMNON: Here, where the bridegroom is, I will—

728

CLYTEMNESTRA: Which of my duties will you perform in the mother's absence?

729

AGAMEMNON: Give your child away with help of Danaids.

730

CLYTEMNESTRA: And where am I to be then?

731

AGAMEMNON: Go to Argos, and take care of your unwedded daughters.

732

CLYTEMNESTRA: And leave my child? Then who will raise her bridal torch?

733

AGAMEMNON: I will provide the proper wedding torch.

734

CLYTEMNESTRA: That is not the custom; but you think lightly of these things.

735

AGAMEMNON: It is not good for you to be alone among a soldier-crowd.

736

CLYTEMNESTRA: It is good that a mother should give her own child away.

737

AGAMEMNON: Yes, and that those maidens at home should not be left alone.

738

CLYTEMNESTRA: They are well guarded in their maiden bowers.

739

AGAMEMNON: Obey.

730

CLYTEMNESTRA: No, by the goddess-queen of Argos! Go, manage matters out of doors; but in the house it is my place to decide [what is proper for maidens at their wedding].⁵⁶

742

AGAMEMNON: Woe is me! my efforts are baffled; I am disappointed in my hope, anxious as I was to get my wife out of sight; foiled at every point, I form my plots and subtle schemes against my best-beloved. But I will go, in spite of all, with Calchas the priest, to inquire the goddess's good pleasure, fraught with ill-luck as it is to me, and with trouble to Hellas.⁵⁷ He who is wise should keep in his house a good and useful wife or none at all.

751

CHORUS: The Hellenes' gathered army will come in arms aboard their ships to Simois with its silver eddies, to Ilium, the plain of Troy

beloved by Phoebus; where Cassandra, I am told, wildly tosses her golden tresses, wreathed with crown of green laurel, whenever the god's resistless prophecies inspire her.

762

CHORUS: And on the towers of Troy and round her walls shall Trojans stand, when sea-borne troops with brazen shields row in on shapely ships to the channels of the Simois, eager to take Helen, the sister of that heavenly pair whom Zeus begot, from Priam, and bear her back to Hellas by toil of Achaean shields and spears.

773

CHORUS: The son of Atreus, encircling Pergamus, the Phrygians' town, with murderous war around her stone-built towers, dragging Paris's head backward to cut his throat and sacking the city⁵⁸ from roof to base, shall be a cause of many tears to maids and Priam's wife. And Helen, the daughter of Zeus, shall⁵⁹ weep in bitter grief because she left her lord. Never may there appear to me or to my children's children the prospect which the wealthy Lydian ladies and Phrygia's brides will have⁶⁰ as at their looms they converse: "Tell me, who will pluck me away from my ruined country, tightening his grasp on lovely tresses till the tears flow? it is all through you, the offspring of the long-necked swan; if indeed it is a true report that Leda bore⁶¹ you to a winged bird, when Zeus transformed himself there, or whether, in the tablets of the poets, fables have carried these tales to men's ears idly, out of season."

801

ACHILLES: Where is Achaea's general? Which of his servants will announce to him that Achilles, the son of Peleus, is at his gates seeking him? For this delay at the Euripus is not the same for all of us; there are some, for instance, who, being still unwed, have left their houses desolate and are idling here upon the beach, while others are married but without children;⁶² so strange the longing for this expedition that has fallen on their hearts by the will of the gods.⁶³ My own just plea I must declare, and whoever else has any wish will speak

for himself. Though I have left Pharsalia, and Peleus, still I linger⁶⁴ here by reason of these light breezes at the Euripus, restraining my Myrmidons, while they are always pressing on me, saying: “Why do we tarry, Achilles? how much longer must we count the days to the start for Ilium? do something if you are so minded; or lead home your men, and do not wait for the tardy action of these Atridae.”

819

CLYTEMNESTRA: Hail to you, son of the Nereid goddess! I heard your voice from within the tent and came forth.

821

ACHILLES: O modesty revered! who can this lady be whom I behold, so richly dowered with beauty’s gifts?

823

CLYTEMNESTRA: No wonder you do not know me, seeing I am one you have never before set eyes on; I praise your reverent address to modesty.

825

ACHILLES: Who are you, and why have you come to the mustering of the Danaids—you, a woman, to a fenced camp of men?

827

CLYTEMNESTRA: I am the daughter of Leda; my name is Clytemnestra; and my husband king Agamemnon.

829

ACHILLES: Well and shortly answered on all important points, but it is shameful for me to stand talking to women.

831

CLYTEMNESTRA: Stay; why seek to escape? give me your hand, a prelude to a happy marriage.

833

ACHILLES: What is it you say? I give you my hand? To lay a finger where I have no right, I could never meet Agamemnon’s eye.

835

CLYTEMNESTRA: The best of rights you have, seeing it is my child you will wed, O son of the sea-goddess, daughter of Nereus.

837

ACHILLES: What wedding do you speak of? Words fail me, lady; can your wits have gone astray and are you inventing this?

839

CLYTEMNESTRA: All men are naturally shy in the presence of new relations, when these remind⁶⁵ them of their wedding.

841

ACHILLES: Lady, I have never courted your daughter, nor have the sons of Atreus ever mentioned marriage to me.

843

CLYTEMNESTRA: What can it mean? Your turn now to marvel at my words, for yours are very strange to me.

845

ACHILLES: Hazard a guess; that we can both do in this matter; for it may be we are both correct in our statements.⁶⁶

847

CLYTEMNESTRA: What! have I suffered such indignity? The marriage I am courting has no reality it seems; I am ashamed of it.

849

ACHILLES: Some one perhaps has made a mock of you and me; pay no heed to it; make light of it.

851

CLYTEMNESTRA: Farewell; I can no longer face you with unfaltering eyes, after being made a liar and suffering undeservedly.

853

ACHILLES: It is "farewell" I bid you too, lady; and I go within the tent to seek your husband.

855

OLD MAN: (*calling through the tent door.*) Stranger of the race of Aeacus, stay awhile! Ho there! I mean you, O goddess-born, and you, daughter

of Leda.

857

ACHILLES: Who is it calling through the half-opened door? What fear his voice betrays!

858

OLD MAN: A slave; of that I am not proud, for fortune does not permit it.

859

ACHILLES: Whose slave are you? not mine; for mine and Agamemnon's goods are separate.

860

OLD MAN: I belong to this lady who stands before the tent, a gift to her from Tyndareus her father.

861

ACHILLES: I am waiting; tell me, if you are desirous, why you have stopped me.

862

OLD MAN: Are you really all alone here at the door?

863

ACHILLES: To us alone will you address yourself; come forth from the king's tent.

864

OLD MAN: (*coming out.*) O Fortune and my own foresight, preserve whom I desire!

865

ACHILLES: That speech will save⁶⁷ them in the future; it has a certain pompous air.

866

CLYTEMNESTRA: Delay not for the sake of touching my right hand, if there is anything that you would say to me.

867

OLD MAN: Well, you know my character and my devotion to you and your children.

868

CLYTEMNESTRA: I know you have grown old in the service of my house.

869

OLD MAN: Likewise you know it was in your dowry king Agamemnon received me.

870

CLYTEMNESTRA: Yes, you came to Argos with me, and have been mine this long time past.

871

OLD MAN: True; and I bear all goodwill to you, less to your husband.

872

CLYTEMNESTRA: Come, come, unfold whatever you have to say.

873

OLD MAN: Her father, he that begot her, is on the point of slaying your daughter with his own hand.

874

CLYTEMNESTRA: How? That for your story, old man! you are mad.

875

OLD MAN: Severing with a sword the hapless girl's white throat.

876

CLYTEMNESTRA: Ah, alas for me! Does my husband happen to have gone mad?

877

OLD MAN: No; he is sane, except where you and your daughter are concerned; there he is mad.

878

CLYTEMNESTRA: What is his reason? what vengeful fiend impels him?

879

OLD MAN: Oracles, at least so Calchas says, in order that the army may start—

880

CLYTEMNESTRA: Where? Alas for me, and for the one her father is going to kill!

881

OLD MAN: To the halls of Dardanus, that Menelaus may recover Helen.

882

CLYTEMNESTRA: So Helen's return then was fated to affect Iphigenia?

883

OLD MAN: You know all; her father is about to offer your child to Artemis.

884

CLYTEMNESTRA: But that marriage—what pretext had it for bringing me from home?

885

OLD MAN: An inducement to you to bring your daughter cheerfully, to wed her to Achilles.

886

CLYTEMNESTRA: On a deadly errand have you come, my daughter, both you, and I, your mother.

887

OLD MAN: Piteous the lot of both of you, and dreadful Agamemnon's venture.

888

CLYTEMNESTRA: Alas, I am undone; my eyes can no longer hold their tears.

889

OLD MAN: If the loss⁶⁸ of children is painful, shed your tears.

890

CLYTEMNESTRA: From where, old man, do you say you had this news?

891

OLD MAN: I had started to carry you a letter referring to the former writing.

892

CLYTEMNESTRA: Forbidding or combining to urge my bringing the child to her death?

893

OLD MAN: No, forbidding it, for your lord was then in his sober senses.

894

CLYTEMNESTRA: How comes it then, if you were really bringing me a letter, that you do not now deliver it into my hands?

895

OLD MAN: Menelaus snatched it from me, he who caused this trouble.

896

CLYTEMNESTRA: Do you hear that, son of Peleus, the Nereid's child?

897

ACHILLES: I have been listening to the tale of your sufferings, and I do not bear my own lightly.

898

CLYTEMNESTRA: They will slay my child; they have tricked her with your marriage.

899

ACHILLES: Like you I blame your lord, nor do I view it with mere indifference.

900

CLYTEMNESTRA: No longer will I let shame⁶⁹ prevent my kneeling to you, a mortal to one goddess-born; why do I affect reserve? whose interests should I consult before my child's? (*Throwing herself before Achilles.*) Oh! help me, goddess-born, in my sore distress, and her that

was called your bride, in vain, it is true, yet called she was. For you it was I wreathed her head and led her forth as if to marriage, but now it is to slaughter I am bringing her. On you will come reproach because you did not help her; for though not wedded to her, yet were you the loving husband of my hapless girl in name at any rate. By your beard, your right hand, and mother too I do implore you; for your name it was that worked my ruin, and you are bound to stand by that. Except your knees I have no altar to fly to; and not a friend stands⁷⁰ at my side. You have heard the cruel abandoned scheme of Agamemnon; and I, a woman, have come, as you see, to a camp of lawless sailor-folk, bold in evil's cause, though useful when they wish; Now if you boldly stretch forth your arm in my behalf, our safety is assured; but if not, we are lost.

917

CHORUS LEADER: A strange thing is motherhood, carrying with it a potent spell, in which all share, so that for their children's sake they will endure affliction.

919

ACHILLES: ⁷¹ My proud spirit is stirred to range aloft, but I have learned to grieve in misfortune and rejoice in high prosperity with equal moderation. For these are the men who can count on ordering all their life rightly by wisdom's rules. True, there are cases where it is pleasant not to be too wise, but there are others, where some store of wisdom helps. Brought up in godly Chiron's halls myself, I learned to keep a single heart; and provided the Atridae lead well, I will obey them; but when they cease from that, no more will I obey; no, but here and in Troy I will show the freedom of my nature, and, as far as in me lies, do honor to Ares with my spear. You, lady, who have suffered so cruelly from your nearest and dearest, I will, by every effort in a young man's power, set right, investing you with that amount of pity and never shall your daughter, after being once called my bride, die by her father's hand; for I will not lend myself to your husband's subtle tricks; no! for it will be my name that kills your child, although it does

not wield the sword. Your own husband is the actual cause, but I shall no longer be guiltless, if, because of me and my marriage, this maiden perishes, she that has suffered past endurance and been the victim of affronts most strangely undeserved. So am I made the poorest wretch in Argos; I a thing of nothing, and Menelaus counting for a man! No son of Peleus I, but the issue of a vengeful fiend, if my name shall⁷² serve your husband for the murder. No! by Nereus, who begot my mother Thetis, in his home amid the flowing waves, never shall king Agamemnon touch your daughter, no! not even to the laying of a finger-tip upon her robe; or Sipylus⁷³, that frontier town of barbarism, the cradle of those chieftains' line, will be henceforth a city indeed, while Phthia's name will nowhere find mention. Calchas, the seer, shall rue beginning the sacrifice with his barley-meal and lustral water. Why, what is a seer? A man who with luck tells the truth sometimes, with frequent falsehoods, but when his luck deserts him, collapses then and there. It is not to secure a bride that I have spoken thus—there are maids unnumbered eager to have my love⁷⁴—no! but king Agamemnon has put an insult on me; he should have asked my leave to use my name as a means to catch the child, for it was I⁷⁵ chiefly who induced Clytemnestra to betroth her daughter to me; I would had yielded this to Hellas, if that was where our going to Ilium broke down; I would never have refused to further my fellow soldiers' common interest. But as it is, I am as nothing in the eyes of those chieftains, and little they care of treating me well or ill. My sword shall soon know if any one is to snatch your daughter from me, for then will I make it reek with the bloody stains of slaughter, before it reach Phrygia.⁷⁶ Calm yourself then; as a god in his might I appeared to you, without being so, but such will I show myself for all that.

975

CHORUS LEADER: Son of Peleus, your words are alike worthy of you and that sea-born deity, the holy goddess.

977

CLYTEMNESTRA: Ah! would I could find words to utter your praise without excess, and yet not lose the graciousness of it by stinting it; for when the good are praised, they have some sort of feeling of hatred for those who in their praise exceed the mean. But I am ashamed of intruding a tale of woe, since my affliction touches myself alone and you are not affected by troubles of mine; but still it looks well for the man of worth to assist the unfortunate, even when he is not connected with them. Therefore pity us, for our suffering cries for pity; in the first place, I have harbored an idle hope, in thinking to have you marry my daughter; and next, perhaps, the slaying of my child will be to you an evil omen in your wooing hereafter, against which you must guard yourself. Your words were good, both first and last; for if you will it so, my daughter will be saved. Will you have her clasp your knees as a suppliant? it is no maid's part; yet if it seems good to you, why, come she shall with the modest look of free-born maid; but if I shall obtain the same end from you without her coming then let her abide within, for there is dignity in her reserve; still reserve must only go as far as the case allows.

998

ACHILLES: ⁷⁷ Do not bring your daughter out for me to see, lady, nor let us incur the reproach of the ignorant; for an army, when gathered together without domestic duties to employ it, loves the evil gossip of malicious tongues. After all, should you both supplicate me, you will attain a like result as if I had never been supplicated;⁷⁸ for I am myself engaged in a mighty struggle to rid you of your troubles. One thing be sure you have heard; I will not tell a lie; if I do that or idly mock you, may I die, but live if I preserve the girl.

1008

CLYTEMNESTRA: Bless you for always helping the distressed!

1009

ACHILLES: Hearken then to me, that the matter may succeed.

1010

CLYTEMNESTRA: What is your proposal? for hear you I must.

1011

ACHILLES: Let us once more urge⁷⁹ her father to a better frame of mind.

1012

CLYTEMNESTRA: He is something of a coward, and fears the army too much.

1013

ACHILLES: Still argument overthrows argument.

1014

CLYTEMNESTRA: Cold hope indeed; but tell me what I must do.

1015

ACHILLES: Supplicate him first not to slay his children; and if he is stubborn, come to me. For⁸⁰ if he consents to your request, my intervention need go no further, since this consent insures your safety. I too shall show myself in a better light to my friend, and the army will not blame me, if I arrange the matter by reason rather than force; while, should things turn out well, the result will prove satisfactory both to you and your friends, even without my interference.

1024

CLYTEMNESTRA: How sensibly you speak! I must act as seems best to you; but should I fail of my object, where am I to see you again, where? Must I turn my wretched steps and find you ready to champion my distress?

1028

ACHILLES: I will keep watch to guard you, where occasion calls, that none may see you passing through the army of Danaids with that scared look. Do not shame your father's house; for Tyndareus does not deserve not to be ill spoken of, being a mighty man in Hellas.⁸¹

1033

CLYTEMNESTRA: It will be so.⁸² Command me; I must play the slave to you. If there are gods, you for your righteous dealing will find them favorable; if there are none, what need to toil?

1035

Exeunt Achilles and Clytemnestra.

1036

CHORUS: What wedding-hymn was that which raised its strains to the sound of Libyan flutes, to the music of the dancer's lyre, and the note of the pipe of reeds? It was on the day Pieria's lovely-haired choir came over the slopes of Pelion to the wedding of Peleus, beating the ground with print of golden sandals at the banquet of the gods, and hymning in dulcet strains the praise of Thetis and the son of Aeacus, over the Centaurs' hill, down woods of Pelion. There was the Dardanian boy, dainty morsel of Zeus' bed, drawing off the wine he mixed in the depths of golden bowls, Ganymede the Phrygian; while, along the gleaming sand, the fifty daughters of Nereus graced the marriage with their dancing, circling in a mazy ring.

1058

CHORUS: The revel-rout of Centaurs came too, mounted on horses, to the feast of the gods and the mixing-bowl of Bacchus, leaning on fir-trees, with⁸³ wreaths of green foliage round their heads; and Chiron cried loudly: "Daughter of Nereus, you shall bear a son, a dazzling light to Thessaly;" and the prophet, skilled in arts inspired by Phoebus, gave his name; "for he shall come with an army of Myrmidon spearmen to the famous land of Priam, to set it in a blaze, his body cased in a suit of golden mail forged by Hephaestus, a gift from his goddess-mother, from Thetis who bore him." Then the gods shed a blessing on the marriage of the high-born bride, who was first of Nereus' daughters, and on the wedding of Peleus.

1080

CHORUS: But the Argives will crown you,⁸⁴ wreathing the lovely tresses of your hair, like a pure, dappled⁸⁵ heifer brought from some rocky cave, and staining with blood your human throat; though you were never reared among the piping and whistling of herdsmen, but at your mother's side, to be decked as the bride of a son of Inachus.⁸⁶ Where now does the face of modesty or virtue have any strength?⁸⁷

seeing that godlessness holds sway, and virtue is neglected by men and thrust behind them, lawlessness over law prevailing, and mortals no⁸⁸ longer making common cause to keep the jealousy of gods from reaching them.

1098

CLYTEMNESTRA: (*reappearing from the tent.*) I have come from the tent to look out for my husband, who went away and left its shelter long ago; while my poor child, hearing of the death her father designs for her, is in tears, uttering in many keys her piteous lamentation. (*Catching sight of Agamemnon.*) It seems I was speaking of one not far away; for there is Agamemnon, who will soon be detected in the commission of a crime against his own child.

1106

AGAMEMNON: Daughter of Leda, it is lucky I have found you outside the tent, to discuss with you in our daughter's absence subjects not suited for the ears of maidens on the eve of marriage.

1109

CLYTEMNESTRA: What critical moment is it that you are seizing?

1110

AGAMEMNON: Send the maiden out to join her father, for the lustral water stands there ready, and barley-meal to scatter with the hand on the cleansing flame, and heifers to be slain before the marriage, in honor of the goddess [Artemis, their black blood spouting from them].

1115

CLYTEMNESTRA: Though the words you use are good, I do not know how I am to name your deeds in terms of praise. Come⁸⁹ forth, my daughter; well you know what is in your father's mind; take the child Orestes, your brother, and bring him with you in the folds of your robe. Behold! she comes, in obedience to your summons. I will speak the rest for her and for myself.

1122

AGAMEMNON: My child, why do you weep and no longer look cheerfully? why are you fixing your eyes upon the ground and holding

your robe before them?

1124

CLYTEMNESTRA: Ah! with which of my woes shall I begin? for I may treat them all as first, or put them last or midway, anywhere.⁹⁰

1127

AGAMEMNON: What is it? I find you all alike, confusion and alarm in every eye.

1129

CLYTEMNESTRA: My husband, answer frankly the questions I ask you.

1130

AGAMEMNON: There is no necessity to order me; I am willing to be questioned.

1131

CLYTEMNESTRA: Do you mean to slay your child and mine?

1132

AGAMEMNON: (*starting.*) Ha! these are heartless words, unwarranted suspicions!

1133

CLYTEMNESTRA: Peace! answer me that question first.

1134

AGAMEMNON: Put a fair question and you shall have a fair answer.

1135

CLYTEMNESTRA: I have no other questions to put; give me no other answers.

1136

AGAMEMNON: O fate revered, O destiny, and my fortune!

1137

CLYTEMNESTRA: Yes, and mine and hers too; the three share one bad fortune.

1138

AGAMEMNON: Whom have I injured?

CLYTEMNESTRA: Do you ask this question? A thought like that itself amounts to thoughtlessness.

1140

AGAMEMNON: Ruined! my secret betrayed!

1141

CLYTEMNESTRA: I know all; I have heard what you are bent on doing to me.⁹¹ Your very silence and those frequent groans are a confession; do not tire yourself by telling it.

1144

AGAMEMNON: See, I am silent; for why should I tell you a falsehood, and add effrontery to misfortune?

1146

CLYTEMNESTRA: Well, now listen; for I will unfold my meaning and no longer employ dark riddles. In the first place—to reproach you first with this—it was not of my own free will but by force that you took and wed me, after slaying Tantalus, my former husband, and dashing⁹² my baby on the ground when you had torn him from my breast with brutal violence. Then those two sons of Zeus, who were my brothers, came flashing on horseback to war with you; but Tyndareus, my old father, rescued you because of your suppliant prayers, and you in turn had me to wife. Once I was reconciled to you upon this footing, you will bear me witness I have been a blameless wife to you and your family, chaste in love, an honor to your house, that so your coming in might be with joy and your going out with gladness. And it is seldom a man secures a wife like this, though the getting of a worthless woman is no rarity. Besides three daughters, of one of whom you are heartlessly depriving me, I am the mother of this son of yours. If anyone asks you your reason for slaying her, tell me, what will you say? or must I say it for you? “It is that Menelaus may recover Helen.” An honorable exchange, indeed, to pay a wicked woman’s price in children’s lives! It is buying what we most detest⁹³ with what we hold most dear. Again, if you go forth with the army, leaving me in your halls and are long absent at Troy, what will my feelings be at home, do

you think? when I behold each vacant chair and her chamber now deserted, and then sit down alone in tears, making ceaseless lamentation for her, “Ah! my child, he that begot you has slain you himself, he and no one else, nor was it by another’s hand,⁹⁴ leaving behind him such a return to his home.” For it needs⁹⁵ now only a trifling pretext for me and the daughters remaining to give you the reception it is right you should receive. I adjure you by the gods, do not compel me to sin against you, or sin yourself.

1185

CLYTEMNESTRA: Well; suppose you sacrifice the child; what prayer will you utter, when it is done? what will the blessing be that you will invoke upon yourself as you are slaying our daughter? An ill returning, seeing the disgrace that speeds your going forth? Is it right that I should pray for any luck to attend you? Surely we should deem the gods devoid of sense, if we harbored a kindly feeling towards murder? Shall you embrace your children on your coming back to Argos? No, you have no right. Will any child of yours ever face you, if you have surrendered one of them to death?⁹⁶ Has this ever entered into your calculations, or does your one duty consist in carrying a scepter about and marching at the head of an army? When you might have made this fair proposal among the Argives; “Is it your wish, Achaeans, to sail for Phrygia’s shores? Why then, cast lots whose daughter has to die.” For that would have been a fair course for you to pursue, instead of picking out your own child for the victim and presenting her to the Danaids; or Menelaus, as it was his concern, should have slain Hermione for her mother. As it is, I, who still am true to your bed, must lose my child; while she, who went astray, will return with her daughter, and live in happiness at Sparta. If I am wrong in my words, answer me; but if they have been fairly urged, do not [still]⁹⁷ slay your child, who is mine too, and you will be wise.

1209

CHORUS LEADER: Harken to her, Agamemnon, for to join in saving your children’s lives is surely a noble deed; no one will deny this.

1211

IPHIGENIA: ⁹⁸ If I had the eloquence of Orpheus, my father, to move the rocks by charmed spells to follow me, or to charm by speaking anyone I wished, I would have resorted to it. But as it is, I'll bring my tears—the only art I know; for that I might attempt. And about your knees, as a suppliant, I twine my limbs—these limbs your wife here bore. Do not destroy me before my time, for it is sweet to look upon the light, and do not force me to visit scenes below. I was the first to call you father, you the first to call me child; I was the first to sit upon your knee and give and take the fond caress. And this was what you would say then: “Shall I see you, my child, living a happy prosperous life in a husband’s home one day, in a manner worthy of myself?” And I in my turn would ask, as I hung about your beard, where I now am clinging, “What then will I do for you? Shall I be giving you a glad reception in my halls, father, in your old age, repaying all your anxious care in rearing me?” I remember all we said, it is you who have forgotten and now would take my life. By Pelops, I entreat you spare me, by your father Atreus and my mother here, who suffers now a second time the pangs she felt before when bearing me! What have I to do with the marriage of Paris and Helen? Why is his coming to prove my ruin, father? Look upon me; bestow one glance, one kiss, that this at least I may carry to my death as a memorial of you, though you do not heed my pleading.⁹⁹ (*holding up the baby Orestes.*) Feeble ally though you are, brother, to your loved ones, yet add your tears to mine and entreat our father for your sister’s life; even in babies there is a natural sense of evil. O father, see this speechless supplication made to you; pity me; have mercy on my tender years! Yes, by your beard we two fond hearts implore your pity, the one a baby, a full-grown maid the other. By summing all my pleas in one, I will prevail in what I say: to gaze upon the light is man’s most cherished gift; that life below is nothingness, and whoever longs for death is mad. Better live a life of woe than die a death of glory!

1253

CHORUS LEADER: Ah, wretched Helen! Great is the struggle that has come sons to the of Atreus and their children, thanks to you and those marriages of yours.

1255

AGAMEMNON: While loving my own children, I yet understand what should move my pity and what should not; I would be a madman otherwise. It is terrible for me to bring myself to this, nor is it less terrible to refuse, daughter; for I must do this.¹⁰⁰ You see the vastness of that naval army, and the numbers of bronze-clad warriors from Hellas, who can neither make their way to Ilium's towers nor raze the far-famed citadel of Troy, unless I offer you according to the word of Calchas the seer.¹⁰¹ Some mad desire possesses the army of Hellas to sail at once to the land of the barbarians, and put a stop to the rape of wives from Hellas, and they will slay my daughter in Argos as well as you and me, if I disregard the goddess's commands. It is not Menelaus who has enslaved me to him, child, nor have I followed his wish; no, it is Hellas, for whom I must sacrifice you whether I will or not; to this necessity I bow my head; for her freedom must be preserved, as far as any help of yours daughter, or mine can go; or they, who are the sons of Hellas, must be pillaged of their wives by barbarian robbery.

1275

Exit Agamemnon.

1276

CLYTEMNESTRA: My child! oh, foreign women! Alas for me, for your death! Your father escapes, surrendering you to Hades.

1279

IPHIGENIA: Alas for me, mother! for the same lament has fallen to both of us in our fortune. No more for me the light of day! no more these beams of the sun! Oh, oh! that snow-beat glen in Phrygia and the hills of Ida, where Priam once exposed a tender baby, torn from his mother's arms to meet a deadly doom, Paris, called the child of Ida in the Phrygians' town. Would that he never had settled Alexander, the herdsman reared among the herds, beside that water crystal-clear,

where are fountains of the Nymphs and their meadow rich with blooming flowers, where hyacinths and rose-buds blow for goddesses to gather! Here one day came Pallas and Cypris of the subtle heart, Hera too and Hermes messenger of Zeus; Cypris, proud of the longing she causes, Pallas of her prowess; and Hera of her royal marriage with king Zeus; to decide a hateful strife about their beauty; but it is my death, maidens, bringing, it is true, glory to the Danaids, that Artemis has received as an offering, before they begin the voyage to Ilium.¹⁰² O mother, mother! he that begot me to this life of sorrow has gone and left me all alone. Ah! woe is me! a bitter, bitter sight for me was Helen, evil Helen! to me now doomed to bleed and die, slaughtered by an impious father! I wish this Aulis had never received in its havens here the stems of their bronze-beaked ships, the fleet which was speeding them to Troy; and would that Zeus had never breathed on the Euripus a wind to stop the expedition,¹⁰³ tempering, as he does, a different breeze to different men, so that some have joy in setting sail, and sorrow some, and others hard constraint, to make some start and others prepare and others delay! Full of trouble then, it seems, is the race of mortals, full of trouble indeed; and it is Fate's decree that man should find distress. Woe! woe to you, you child of Tyndareus, for the suffering and anguish sore, which you are causing the Danaids!

1336

CHORUS LEADER: I pity you for your cruel fate—a fate I would you never had met!

1338

IPHIGENIA: O mother that bore me! I see a throng of men approaching.

1339

CLYTEMNESTRA: It is the goddess' son you see, child, for whom you came here.

1340

IPHIGENIA: (*calling into the tent.*) Open the tent-door to me, servants, that I may hide myself

1341

CLYTEMNESTRA: Why seek to escape, my child?

IPHIGENIA: I am ashamed to face Achilles.

1342

CLYTEMNESTRA: But why?

IPHIGENIA: The luckless ending to our marriage causes me to feel abashed.

1343

CLYTEMNESTRA: No time for affectation now in face of what has happened. Stay then; reserve will do no good, if we may profit.¹⁰⁴

1345

ACHILLES: Daughter of Leda, lady of sorrows!

CLYTEMNESTRA: No misnomer that.

1346

ACHILLES: A fearful cry is heard among the Argives.

CLYTEMNESTRA: What is it? tell me.

1347

ACHILLES: It concerns your child.

CLYTEMNESTRA: An evil omen for your words.

1348

ACHILLES: They say her sacrifice is necessary.

CLYTEMNESTRA: And is there no one to say a word against them?

1349

ACHILLES: Indeed I was in some danger myself from the tumult.

CLYTEMNESTRA: In danger of what, stranger?.

1350

ACHILLES: Of being stoned.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Surely not for trying to save my daughter?

1351

ACHILLES: The very reason.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Who would have dared to lay a finger on you?

1352

ACHILLES: All the men of Hellas.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Were not your Myrmidon warriors at your side?

1353

ACHILLES: They were the first who turned against me.

CLYTEMNESTRA: My child! we are lost, it seems.

1354

ACHILLES: They taunted me as the man whom marriage had enslaved.

CLYTEMNESTRA: And what did you answer them?

1355

ACHILLES: Not to kill the one I meant to wed—

CLYTEMNESTRA: Justly so.

1356

ACHILLES: The wife her father promised me.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Yes, and sent to fetch from Argos.

1357

ACHILLES: But I was overcome by clamorous cries.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Truly the mob is a dire mischief.

1358

ACHILLES: But I will help you for all that.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Will you really fight them single-handed?

1359

ACHILLES: Do you see these warriors here, carrying my arms?

CLYTEMNESTRA: Bless you for your kind intent!

1360

ACHILLES: Well, I shall be blessed.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Then my child will not be slaughtered now?

1361

ACHILLES: No, not with my consent at any rate.

CLYTEMNESTRA: But will any of them come to lay hands on the maid?

1362

ACHILLES: Thousands of them, with Odysseus at their head.

CLYTEMNESTRA: The son of Sisyphus?

1363

ACHILLES: The very same.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Acting for himself or by the army's order?

1364

ACHILLES: By their choice—and his own.

CLYTEMNESTRA: An evil choice indeed, to stain his hands in blood.

1365

ACHILLES: But I will hold him back.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Will he seize and bear her off against her will?

1366

ACHILLES: Yes, by her golden hair no doubt.

CLYTEMNESTRA: What must I do, when it comes to that?

1367

ACHILLES: Keep hold of your daughter.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Be sure that she shall not be slain, as far as that that can help her.

1368

ACHILLES: Believe me, it will come to this.¹⁰⁵

IPHIGENIA: Mother, hear me while I speak, for I see that you are angry with your husband to no purpose; it is hard for us to persist in impossibilities. Our thanks are due to this stranger for his ready help;

but you must also see to it that he is not reproached by the army, leaving us no better off and himself involved in trouble. Listen, mother; hear what thoughts have passed across my mind. I am resolved to die; and this I want to do with honor, dismissing from me what is mean. Towards this now, mother turn your thoughts, and with me weigh how well I speak; to me the whole of mighty Hellas looks; on me the passage over the sea depends; on me the sack of Troy; and in my power it lies to check henceforth barbarian raids on happy Hellas, if ever in the days to come they seek to seize her women, when once they have atoned by death¹⁰⁶ for the violation of Helen's marriage by Paris. All this deliverance will my death insure, and my fame for setting Hellas free will be a happy one. Besides, I have no right at all to cling too fondly to my life; for you did not bear me for myself alone, but as a public blessing to all Hellas. What! shall countless warriors, armed with shields, those myriads sitting at the oar, find courage to attack the foe and die for Hellas, because their fatherland is wronged, and my one life prevent all this? What¹⁰⁷ kind of justice is that? could I find a word in answer? Now let us turn to that other point. It is not right that this man should enter into battle with all Argos or be slain for a woman's sake. Better a single man should see the light than ten thousand women. If Artemis has decided to take my body, am I, a mortal, to thwart the goddess? no, that is impossible. I give my body to Hellas; sacrifice it and make an utter end of Troy. This is my enduring monument; marriage, motherhood, and fame—all these is it to me. And it is right, mother, that Hellenes should rule barbarians, but not barbarians Hellenes, those being slaves, while these are free.

1402

CHORUS LEADER: You play a noble part, maiden; but the whims of Fate and the goddess are diseased.

1404

ACHILLES: Daughter of Agamemnon! some god was bent on blessing me, if I could have won you for my wife. In you I consider Hellas happy, and you in Hellas; for this that you have said is good and

worthy of your fatherland; since you, abandoning a strife with heavenly powers, which are too strong for you, have fairly weighed advantages and needs.¹⁰⁸ But now that I have looked into your noble nature, I feel still more a fond desire to win you for my bride. Look to it; for I want to serve you and receive you in my halls; and, Thetis be my witness, how I grieve to think I shall not save your life by doing battle with the Danaids. Reflect, I say; a dreadful ill is death.

1416

IPHIGENIA: This I say, without regard to anyone.¹⁰⁹ Enough that the daughter of Tyndareus is causing wars and bloodshed by her beauty; then be not slain yourself, stranger, nor seek to slay another on my account; but let me, if I can, save Hellas.

1421

ACHILLES: Heroic spirit! I can say no more to this, since you are so minded; for yours is a noble resolve; why should not one speak the truth? Yet I will speak, for you will perhaps change your mind; [that you may know then what my offer is,] I will go and place these arms of mine near the altar, resolved not to permit your death but to prevent; for brave as you are at sight of the knife held at your throat, you will soon avail yourself of what I said. So I will not let you perish through any thoughtlessness of yours, but will go to the goddess with these arms and await your arrival there.¹¹⁰

1432

Exit Achilles.

1433

IPHIGENIA: Mother, why so silent, your eyes wet with tears?

1434

CLYTEMNESTRA: I have reason, woe is me! to be sad at heart.

1435

IPHIGENIA: Stop; do not make me a coward; here in one thing obey me.

1436

CLYTEMNESTRA: Tell me, my child, for at my hands you shall never suffer injury.

1437

IPHIGENIA: Cut not off the tresses of your hair for me, nor clothe yourself in sable garb.¹¹¹

1439

CLYTEMNESTRA: Why, my child, what is it you have said? When I have lost you?¹¹²

1440

IPHIGENIA: You will not lose me; I am saved and you renowned, as far as I can make you.

1441

CLYTEMNESTRA: How so? Must I not mourn your death?

1442

IPHIGENIA: By no means, for I shall have no tomb heaped over me.

1443

CLYTEMNESTRA: What then? It is death, not the tomb, that is rightly mourned.

1444

IPHIGENIA: The altar of the goddess, Zeus's daughter, will be my tomb.

1445

CLYTEMNESTRA: Well, my child, I will let you persuade me, for you speak well.

1446

IPHIGENIA: Yes, as one who prospers and does Hellas service.

1447

CLYTEMNESTRA: What message shall I carry to your sisters?

1448

IPHIGENIA: Do not put mourning raiment on them either.

1449

CLYTEMNESTRA: But is there no fond message I can give the maidens from you?

1450

IPHIGENIA: Yes, my farewell words; and promise me to rear Orestes to manhood.

1451

CLYTEMNESTRA: Press him to your bosom; it is your last look.

1452

IPHIGENIA: O you that are most dear to me! you have helped your friends as you had means.

1453

CLYTEMNESTRA: Is there anything I can do in Argos to please you?

1454

IPHIGENIA: Yes, do not hate my father, your own husband.

1455

CLYTEMNESTRA: Fearful are the trials through which he has to go because of you.

1456

IPHIGENIA: It was against his will he ruined me for the sake of Hellas.

1457

CLYTEMNESTRA: Ah! but he employed base treachery, unworthy of Atreus.

1458

IPHIGENIA: Who will escort me from here, before my hair is torn?

1459

CLYTEMNESTRA: I will go with you—

IPHIGENIA: No, not you; that is not well said.

1460

CLYTEMNESTRA: Clinging to your robes.

IPHIGENIA: Be persuaded by me, mother, stay here; for this is the better way both for me and you; but let one of these attendants of my

father conduct me to the meadow of Artemis, where I shall be sacrificed.

1464

CLYTEMNESTRA: Are you gone from me, my child?

IPHIGENIA: Yes, and with no chance of ever returning.

1465

CLYTEMNESTRA: Leaving your mother?

IPHIGENIA: Yes, as you see, undeservedly.

1466

CLYTEMNESTRA: Hold! do not leave me!

IPHIGENIA: I cannot let you shed a tear. (*To the Chorus.*) May it be yours, maidens, to hymn in joyous strains Artemis, the child of Zeus, for my hard lot; and let the order for a solemn hush go forth to the Danaids. Begin the sacrifice with the baskets, let the fire blaze for the purifying meal of sprinkling, and my father pace from left to right about the altar; for I come to bestow on Hellas safety crowned with victory.

1475

IPHIGENIA: Lead me away, the destroyer of Ilium's town and the Phrygians; give me wreaths to cast about me; bring them here; here are my tresses to crown; bring lustral water too. Dance to Artemis, queen Artemis the blest, around her shrine and altar; for by the blood of my sacrifice I will blot out the oracle, if it must be. O mother, lady revered! I will, not give you my tears; for at the holy rites it is not fitting.¹¹³ Sing with me, maidens, sing the praises of Artemis, whose temple faces Chalcis, where angry spearmen madly chafe, here in the narrow havens of Aulis, because of me. O Pelasgia, land of my birth, and Mycenae, my home!

1500

CHORUS: Is it on Perseus' citadel you call, that town Cyclopean workmen built?

1502

IPHIGENIA: To be a light to Hellas did you rear me, and so I do not say
No to death.

1504

CHORUS: You are right; no fear that fame will ever desert you!

1505

IPHIGENIA: Hail to you, bright lamp of day and light of Zeus! A
different life, a different lot is henceforth mine. Farewell I bid you,
light beloved!

1509

Exit Iphigenia.

1510

CHORUS: [¹¹⁴ Behold the maiden on her way, the destroyer of Ilium's
town and the Phrygians, with garlands twined about her head, and
drops of lustral water on her, soon to be sprinkled with her gushing
blood the altar of a murderous goddess, when her shapely neck is
severed.¹¹⁵ For you fair streams of a father's pouring and lustral waters
are in store, for you Achaea's army is waiting, eager to reach the
citadel of Ilium. But let us celebrate Artemis, the daughter of Zeus,
queen among the gods, as if upon some happy chance. O lady revered,
delighting in human sacrifice, send on its way to Phrygia's land the
army of the Hellenes, to Troy's abodes of guile, and grant that
Agamemnon may wreath his head with deathless fame, a crown of
fairest glory for the spearmen of Hellas.¹¹⁶]

1532

MESSENGER: [Come forth, O Clytemnestra, daughter of Tyndareus,
from the tent, to hear my news.]

1534

CLYTEMNESTRA: [I heard your voice and have come in sad dismay
and fearful dread, not sure but what you have arrived with tidings of
some fresh trouble for me besides the present woe.]

1537

MESSENGER: [No, rather I want to unfold to you a strange and marvellous story about your child.]

1539

CLYTEMNESTRA: [Do not delay, then, but speak at once.]

1540

MESSENGER: [Dear mistress, you shall learn all clearly; from the outset will I tell it, unless my memory fails me somewhat and confuses my tongue in its account. As soon as we reached the grove of Artemis, the child of Zeus, and the flowery meadows, where the Achaean troops were gathered, bringing your daughter with us, at once the Argive army began assembling; but when king Agamemnon saw the maiden on her way to the grove to be sacrificed, he gave one groan, and, turning away his face, let the tears burst from his eyes, as he held his robe before them. But the maid, standing close by her father, spoke thus: "O my father, here I am; willingly I offer my body for my country and all Hellas, that you may lead me to the altar of the goddess and sacrifice me, since this is Heaven's ordinance. May good luck be yours for any help that I afford! and may you obtain the victor's gift and come again to the land of your fathers. So then let none of the Argives lay hands on me, for I will bravely yield my neck without a word." She spoke; and each man marvelled, as he heard the maiden's brave speech. But in the midst Talthybius stood up, for this was his duty, and bade the army refrain from word or deed; and Calchas, the seer, drawing a sharp sword from its scabbard laid it in a basket of beaten gold, and crowned the maiden's head. Then the son of Peleus, taking the basket and with it lustral water in his hand, ran round the altar of the goddess uttering these words: "O Artemis, you child of Zeus, slayer of wild beasts, that wheel your dazzling light amid the gloom, accept this sacrifice which we, the army of the Achaeans and Agamemnon with us, offer to you, pure blood from a beautiful maiden's neck; and grant us safe sailing for our ships and the sack of Troy's towers by our spears." Meanwhile the sons of Atreus and all the army stood looking on the ground.]

1578

MESSENGER: [But the priest, seizing his knife, offered up a prayer and was closely scanning the maiden's throat to see where he should strike. It was no slight sorrow filled my heart, as I stood by with bowed head; when there was a sudden miracle! Each one of us distinctly heard the sound of a blow,¹¹⁷ but none saw the spot where the maiden vanished. The priest cried out, and all the army took up the cry at the sight of a marvel all unlooked for, due to some god's agency, and passing all belief, although it was seen; for there upon the ground lay a deer of immense size, magnificent to see, gasping out her life, with whose blood the altar of the goddess was thoroughly bedewed. Then spoke Calchas thus—his joy you can imagine—"You captains of this leagued Achaean army, do you see this victim, which the goddess has set before her altar, a mountain-roaming deer? This is more welcome to her by far than the maid, that she may not defile her altar by shedding noble blood. Gladly she has accepted it, and is granting us a prosperous voyage for¹¹⁸ our attack on Ilium. Therefore take heart, sailors, each man of you, and away to your ships, for today we must leave the hollow bays of Aulis and cross the Aegean main." Then, when the sacrifice was wholly burnt to ashes in the blazing flame, he offered such prayers as were fitting, that the army might win return; but Agamemnon sends me to tell you this, and say what heaven-sent luck is his, and how he has secured undying fame throughout the length of Hellas. Now I was there myself and speak as an eyewitness; without a doubt your child flew away to the gods. A truce then to your sorrowing, and cease to be angry with your husband; for the gods' ways with man are not what we expect, and those whom they love, they keep safe; yes, for this day has seen your daughter dead and living.]

1613

Exit Messenger.

CHORUS LEADER: [What joy to hear these tidings from the messenger! He tells you your child is living still, among the gods.]

1615

CLYTEMNESTRA: [Which of the gods, my child, has stolen you? How am I to address you? How can I be sure¹¹⁹ that this is not an idle tale told to cheer me, to make me cease my piteous lamentation for you?]

1619

CHORUS: [See! king Agamemnon approaches, to confirm this story for you.]

1621

AGAMEMNON: [Lady, we may be counted¹²⁰ happy, as far as concerns our daughter; for in truth she has fellowship with gods. But you must take this tender¹²¹ child and start for home, for the army is looking now to sail. Fare you well! it is long before I shall greet you on my return from Troy; may it be well with you!]

1627

CHORUS: [Son of Atreus, start for Phrygia's land with joy and so return, I pray, after taking from Troy her fairest spoils.]

Notes

¹ Reading ὅτῳ with Boissonade and Monk. Hermann retaining ὅρου gives the sense as, “whosoever love, acceptable to her, impelled her to choose him.”

² Paley reads πᾶσι for MSS κᾶτα. Others gives κάρτα.

³ Nauck rejects l. 93.

⁴ The arrangement of the following lines is uncertain. Monk, omitting ll. 10-13, σιγαῖ δ' — ἄναξ as interpolated, gives the whole passage down to l. 16, στείχωμεν ἔσω to the aged attendant. Paley considers this the most likely arrangement.

⁵ Others join ἐνταῦθα βίου, “in this position in life.”

⁶ τὸ φιλότιμον of the MSS., but the verse is probably corrupt, being regarded by Hermann and Dindorf as a gloss on τὸ καλόν.

⁷ περί σοι, but Monk's πάρα σοι, “what news has reached thee?” is a plausible emendation.

⁸ Paley follows Musgrave in assigning these words to Agamemnon, assuming that the king passes over the servant's last remark and adds a new cause of alarm, viz., the fraud that is being practiced on Achilles.

⁹ Lines 124-32 are rejected by some editors. Hennig supposes them to be the work of the younger Euripides.

¹⁰ The old man cuts short Agamemnon's warnings, as being an un-called-for reflection on his own loyalty.

¹¹ Paley retains the MSS. κλήθρων δ' ἐξόρμα, omitting νιν with Monk in l. 150; Wecklein, reading ἐξορμώσαις to agree with πομπαῖς retains νιν. Hermann transposes the verse after l. 152, and so Nauck edits.

¹² Dindorf, with whom Paley agrees, regards ll. 171-84 as the work of a later hand, and gives good reasons for his opinion.

¹³ The whole of the following long passage from l.192-302 is inclosed in brackets by Paley. Dindorf and Hermann condemn the greater part, retaining a few lines here and there.

¹⁴ To turn the post without losing ground would require the driver to rein in his near trace-horse and let the outer one come round on a curve, "facing the turning-post".

¹⁵ The reading μείλινον ἀδονάν of the MSS. cannot be right, nor are many of the proposed emendations much more probable; in the absence of anything more intelligible, Markland's μείλιχον is here adopted.

¹⁶ Paley reads ἀδελφὸς with Markland for Ἄδραστος of the old copies.

¹⁷ This line is corrupt, and perhaps the next also. The attempted version follows Weil.

¹⁸ The word ἄιον before εἰδόμεν is probably a gloss on that verb. Some editors adopt Hermann's οἶον, but there is no certainty in it.

¹⁹ The point lies in the play on the name Ἀτρεΰς, i.e., "the fearless," "shall I the son of fearlessness, fear, etc.?"

²⁰ Reading εὖ κεκόμψευσαι πονηρά with Ruhnken and Monk.

²¹ Reading οὔτε κατατενῶ with Hermann.

²² Reading ἦλθες with Monk.

²³ Nauck, following Dindorf's suggestion, regards ll. 351 and 354-5 as interpolations, foisted in to supply gaps in the MSS., and he therefore omits them,

marking a lacuna after l. 353.

²⁴ Line 359 is regarded by Nauck as spurious.

²⁵ μάλιστά γε. L. Dindorf proposed κάλλιστά γε, ironical “very fine!” Both this and the previous line are omitted in Nauck’s text as spurious.

²⁶ This line was thus transposed by Paley from its usual position after l. 365.

²⁷ There is some corruption in this line; perhaps Monk’s μηδέν’ οὖν γένους ἕκατι (Nauck ἄρα for οὖν), supplies the required sense best.

²⁸ Following Hermann’s punctuation. Monk retains the stop after πόλεος, “the head of the state must have sense; for every man, if so gifted, is a ruler.” Hennig condemns l. 374.

²⁹ Paley follows Markland in reading αὖ for MSS. εὔ.

³⁰ Reading ἦγε δ’ with Matthiae for MSS. ἡ δέ γ’.

³¹ Paley adopts Monk’s ἔτομοι δ’ εἰσὶ for γ’ οἶμαι δ’ εἶσθι, but follows Dindorf’s punctuation in not making these words parenthetical. Hermann gives ἐγῶμαι, μωρίαν εἶσθι φρενῶν, “thou wilt find out their folly, I expect.”

³² In this difficult and much emended passage Lenting’s κοῦ for καὶ Reiske’s παρὰ δίκης, and τιμωρίᾳ, dat. for nom., are the readings followed.

³³ Lines 413-41 are regarded by Kirchhoff as the work of a much later age. Nauck incloses them in brackets, but Paley, Monk, and Hermann agree in retaining them as probably genuine.

³⁴ Reading ὥς τι τερφθεῖης with Hermann for ὥστε; if ὥστε is retained the meaning apparently is “therefore, mayst thou rejoice at seeing him,” involving rather an awkward parenthesis.

³⁵ τε was added by Hermann, because Menelaus could only be invited to take part in the ceremony as an assistant, all important duties devolving on the bride’s parents.

³⁶ The meaning seems to be that though both classes have the same sorrows, the high-born are prevented by their sense of dignity from giving way to any outward expression of them for their relief. In l. 450 ὄγκον, the reading restored from Plutarch, is followed rather than the old δῆμον.

³⁷ Reading εἶμι of MSS. Kirchhoff proposed εἰμί, i.e., “I share thy views.”

³⁸ Lines 508-10 are rejected by most editors as an interpolation; omitting them, Agamemnon’s speech goes on naturally at l. 511. Hermann, retaining them,

replaces γε by δὲ and continues them to Agamemnon.

³⁹ ἐξαλλάσσουσιν χάριν. Liddell and Scott render as above. Paley follows Hermann in rendering “a compensating pleasure.” The whole of this chorus is so full, however, of corruption, and possibly interpolation, that it is not unlikely that this phrase was not of Euripides’ coining.

⁴⁰ Reading κόσμος ἐνὼν ὁ μυριπληθής with Markland, but here again it is hopeless to recover the true reading.

⁴¹ Reading ὅθι with Hartung.

⁴² The whole passage from l. 574-606 is regarded by Paley and Dindorf as an interpolation; while most editors concur in regarding ll. 599-606 as undoubtedly spurious.

⁴³ κῶλον ἀσθενές θ’ ἄμα, but Hermann’s κῶλον ἀσφαλῶς χαμαί is tempting.

⁴⁴ νεάνιδες, νίν so Pierson for νεανίδασιν.

⁴⁵ The passages inclosed in brackets are regarded by Paley and Dindorf, and, in the main, by Kirchhoff, as spurious. Monk only omits ll. 627-30, and ll. 635-7.

⁴⁶ These two lines were placed here by Porson instead of after the next distich; the same critic read προσβαλῶ and περιβαλεῖν instead of περιβαλῶ and προσβαλεῖν; both of which changes are followed in the translation, though Paley, while mentioning the second, has not actually adopted it in his text.

⁴⁷ This line is corrupt, though the sense, so far, is preserved. Dindorf suspects ll. 652-5, and it certainly is difficult to see the connection of l. 652 with what precedes. Paley suggests that several lines have been lost.

⁴⁸ θέλω γε· τὸ θέλειν δ’ but the words are probably corrupt.

⁴⁹ ἄλλους ὀλεῖ πρόσθ’ ἀμὲ διολέσαντ’ ἔχει. None of the various proposed emendations are great improvements on this reading of Porson’s, though it is hardly likely that this is what Euripides wrote.

⁵⁰ These two lines, 665-6 are corrupt, probably interpolated, in Paley’s opinion. Omitting them, l. 667 comes in very properly. To obtain any sense in the first of them, Weil’s correction, ἐς ταῦτὸν αὖθις, ὧ θύγατερ ἤξεις πατρί has been adopted; the meaning being, “we shall meet after death.”

⁵¹ Reading ἀλλ’ ἔστι, Hermann’s correction for MSS. αἰτεῖς τι.

⁵² Monk interprets “in a matter of religion thou must consult the priests.” Paley inclines to the view that ll. 674-7 are interpolated.

⁵³ The old name of Aegina.

⁵⁴ ἀπάξεις, so Dobree for ἀπάξει.

⁵⁵ Reading καλῶς γ', ἀνασκαίως δέ, as Paley edits on his own correction.

⁵⁶ This line is rejected by Monk as spurious; Hermann proposes to read νυμφίοισι παρθένων, and without some such emendation it is difficult to find any meaning in it.

⁵⁷ Lines 746-8 are rejected by Monk, whom most editors follow.

⁵⁸ The words πόλισμα Τροίας are omitted by Monk as a gloss on πόλιν. Hartung regards ll. 773-83 as interpolated, and there is certainly much in them that Euripides can scarcely have written; both Dindorf and Kirchhoff reject large portions of what follows l. 773.

⁵⁹ ἐσέϊται. Hermann gives εἴσεται, "shall know to her cost."

⁶⁰ Perhaps Tyrwhitt's σχήσουσι should be read for στήσουσι.

⁶¹ Reading ἔτεκεν with Musgrave for ἔτυχεν.

⁶² Reading καὶ παῖδας with Musgrave for ἄπαιδες.

⁶³ τῆσδε στρατείας οὐκ ἄνευ θεῶν τινός. Hennig rejects ll. 805-9.

⁶⁴ Kirchhoff marks a lacuna of three lines after l. 812 on the authority of one MS.; it is possible, however, that the passage is continuous, and an attempt has been made here to treat it as such.

⁶⁵ μεμνημένους, so Hermann and Dindorf; if μεμνημένοις be retained from the MSS., the meaning must be "when they call their marriage to mind"; the latter is preferred by Kirchhoff and Monk.

⁶⁶ i.e., we may both be right, but at cross purposes. Markland proposes ἐφευδόμεθα, "we may both have been deceived in what we say."

⁶⁷ Reading σώσει, Monk's correction for ἂν ὤση. Others read ἀνοίσει with Markland, or ὀνήσει with Böckh.

⁶⁸ Reading with Wecklein εἴπερ ἄλλ' εἰκός. Paley retains the old reading εἴπερ ἀλγεινόν. Hartung gives οὐ γὰρ ἄλογόν ἐστι. Kirchhoff οὐ γὰρ ἄλλ' εἰκός.

⁶⁹ Reading οὐκέτ' αἰδεσθησόμεσθα, a conjecture of Nauck and Hermann's. Paley regards ll. 900-2 as spurious.

⁷⁰ Reading πέλας with Markland for MSS. γελαῖ, a conjecture adopted by Hermann and Monk.

⁷¹ On the following speech Paley has this remark: “there are very grave reasons for doubting whether the genuine speech of Achilles has not been superseded, either wholly or in part, by the verses of a cunning imitator.” The reasoning throughout is extremely difficult to follow, if indeed possible, and there are numerous exceptional phrases. Dindorf incloses large portions of this speech in brackets, but it is hard to see why he decides one part to be more suspicious than another.

⁷² Reading φονεύσει with Schäfer.

⁷³ A mountain in Lycia, near which was shown the grave of Tantalus, the ancestor of the Atridae; the town of the same name was swallowed up in very early times by an earthquake.

⁷⁴ Reading οὐ for ἤ, and regarding μυρίαί—τούμὸν as parenthetical, which in the main is the view taken by Nauck and Klotz of this very unsatisfactory passage. Paley, regarding it as an interpolation, disdains to emend it.

⁷⁵ i.e., it was my rank, etc., as described by Agamemnon, that carried the day, and, such being the case, I ought to have had some voice in the matter. (Paley.)

⁷⁶ Porson, whom Monk follows, corrects this passage thus: ὄν, πρὶν εἰς Φρύγας | ἐλθεῖν φόνον, κλῖσιν αἵματος χρανῶ, an ingenious but not absolutely necessary emendation.

⁷⁷ Paley regards ll. 998-1035 as spurious, pointing out much, that, in his opinion, stamps them as the work of a later hand.

⁷⁸ Reading ἦν for ἦς, as Paley suggests; Nauck gives ἀνικετεύτως εἷς, to avoid the un-Attic εἰ . . . ἦς.

⁷⁹ Reading πείθωμεν.

⁸⁰ Dindorf marks ll. 1017-23 as spurious; “the only wonder is,” says Paley, “that he tolerated the preceding part.”

⁸¹ Line 1032 is inclosed in brackets by Nauck.

⁸² ἔστιν τάδ’. So Paley; but others, with Markland, read ἔσται τάδ’ i.e., “I will do as you say.”

⁸³ Reading ἀνὰ δ’ ἐλάταις σὺν with Weil.

⁸⁴ i.e., Iphigenia.

⁸⁵ Reading βαλιάν for γ’ ἀλιᾶν with Scaliger, with Monk’s addition of ἔλαφον, and his further correction ὀρείαν ἦ.

⁸⁶ From here to the end of the chorus is regarded by Paley as spurious.

⁸⁷ Omitting the words δύνασιν ἔχει as a probable gloss on σθένει (MSS. σθένειν); so Paley and Weil.

⁸⁸ Paley follows Hermann in inserting μὴ to complete the metre.

⁸⁹ Paley thinks ll.1117-23 were interpolated by way of making the entrance of Iphigenia with Orestes (cf. l. 1241) appear less abrupt.

⁹⁰ This line was rejected by Monk, whom most editors follow.

⁹¹ Paley regards this line as spurious; the use of σύ, where no emphasis seems intended, is his main reason for rejecting it.

⁹² Reading προσούδισας πέδῳ (Scaliger) and ζῶν (Musgrave) for the MSS. σῶ προσούρισας πάλῳ, which Hermann explains as meaning “having added him to your share in the division of the spoils.” Hartung gives προσώρισας.

⁹³ Reading τᾶχθιστα τοῖσι.

⁹⁴ Paley thinks a line has here fallen out to the effect, “How wilt thou dare to return to thy wife and . . .” Monk rejects l. 1179; omitting it, the sense might be continuous, thus; “Thy father was the real murderer and no one else; for it only needed a slight excuse on thy part and the sacrifice might have been prevented . . .”; but this is extremely awkward, and Paley’s view is preferable.

⁹⁵ Reading ἐνδεῖ with Reiske.

⁹⁶ Reading ἐὰν σφῶν προέμενος, as Nauck edits from the joint correction of Hartung and Elmsley.

⁹⁷ The reading adopted by Paley is εἰ δ’ εὔ λέλεκται τάμᾳ, μηκέτι . . . for the admittedly corrupt reading of the MSS.

⁹⁸ Paley thinks that Iphigenia now advances on to the stage with the child Orestes, and throws herself at Agamemnon’s knees.

⁹⁹ Nauck incloses l. 1240 in brackets as suspicious.

¹⁰⁰ Paley follows Kirchhoff in reading ταῦτά. Others retain τοῦτο and render “I must do this deed.”

¹⁰¹ The following passage from l. 1264-75 is regarded by Dindorf as spurious. Hennig thinks l. 1269 and ll. 1271-75 are genuine.

¹⁰² Reading μὰν for μὲν and ἐμόν for ἐμοί, also προθύματ’ for πρόθυμά ς’ in this hopelessly corrupt passage. Monk, rejecting ὄνομα . . . Δαναΐδαισιν, assigns the next two lines to the Chorus, merely altering κόραι to κόρα, but this is scarcely likely to be the solution of the difficulty.

¹⁰³ Reading πομπᾶ. The whole of this passage (l. 1323-29) is probably more or less corrupt, and the construction suspiciously harsh; possibly the text has suffered from interpolations and glosses on the original.

¹⁰⁴ The sentence is left unfinished, owing to the sudden address of Achilles; possibly it would have run “if only we can enlist his aid.”

¹⁰⁵ i.e., to an actual appeal to force.

¹⁰⁶ Lines 1381-2 are corrupt. The corrections here followed are τάσδ’ for τὰς in l. 1381, and ὀλέθρῳ γάμον ὄν Hermann’s emendation of ὀλεθρον, ἦντιν’ in l. 1382.

¹⁰⁷ Reading Hermann’s correction of this corrupt line, τί τὸ δίκαιον τοῦτ’ ὅ γ’; ἄρ’ ἔχοιμ’ ἂν ἀντειπεῖν ἔπος;

¹⁰⁸ These two lines 1409-10 are rejected by Monk; Dindorf thinks the entire passage from l. 1408-33 spurious, an opinion in which Paley does not concur.

¹⁰⁹ The words οὐδὲν οὐδέν’ εὐλαβουμένη have small MSS. authority, and were probably inserted by a grammarian to complete the verse.

¹¹⁰ Lines 1431-3 are rejected by Monk. Nauck, on Dindorf’s authority, also incloses l. 1426 and ll. 1429-33 in brackets.

¹¹¹ This line was rejected by Hermann, Burges, and most other editors.

¹¹² The aposiopesis may be supplied by “forbear to mourn.”

¹¹³ Lines 1488-90 are assigned by some editors to the Chorus, but there seems little reason for the arrangement.

¹¹⁴ Paley agrees with Porson in regarding the rest of the play after Iphigenia’s exit as the work of an interpolator; he follows as his text Kirchhoff’s collation of the MSS., only noticing a few corrections; for the purposes of translation some further variations are here admitted.

¹¹⁵ Lines 1514-16 read διαίμονος with Markland for γε δαίμονος; ῥανοῦσαν, Markland for θανοῦσαν; and omit τε with Bothe after εὐφυᾶ.

¹¹⁶ Reading Ἑλλάσι with Markland for Ἑλλάδι.

¹¹⁷ Reading πληγῆς σαφῶς γὰρ πᾶς τις ἦσθετο κτύπον (Weil).

¹¹⁸ Reading Ἰλίου πρὸς for Ἰλίου τ’ with Hermann.

¹¹⁹ By omitting the stop after φῶ as Nauck edits, and making the sentence continuous, perhaps the simplest explanation of this passage is obtained.

¹²⁰ To correct the scansion Hermann proposes ὀλβιζοίμεθ’ ἄν.

¹²¹ νεαγενῇ, for which Porson gives εὐγενῇ to correct the metre.